Alexander 9.1 — What's New

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Overview

Alexander 9.1 is a live book release on top of Alexander 9. The search, the evaluation, Handicap mode, the avatars and The Master's Verdict are the same: the bench signature is still 3905509 nodes.

It adds the **LiveBook Width** option, so that the live books stop repeating the same move, and fixes crashes and wrong moves of the live books and the online tablebases.

New: LiveBook Width

Until 9 the live books always played their top move, even when other moves were just as good. **LiveBook Width** (1–20, default 1) works like **Book N Width** of the CTG/BIN books: the engine picks at random, with the same probability, among the best move and up to Width − 1 moves equivalent to it.

Source	Equivalent moves	Order of the moves
ChessDB	The moves ChessDB ranks best (`!`, rank 2): a few centipawns from the best one at most	ChessDB score
Lichess Masters, Games, Player	Same Shashin zone of the success rate (wins + draws / 2 for the side to move) as the best move, and played in at least 0.5% of the games, as for the BIN books	Wins, then draws
Proxy	The proxy sends a single move (use LiveBook Proxy Diversity for variety)	—
Lichess and ChessDB tablebases	None: always the best move	Order of the server

With the avatars this gives the variety of a real repertoire. **LiveBook Lichess Player** with a width above 1 alternates the lines of that player that score in the same Shashin zone, instead of repeating the most played one. **LiveBook Lichess Games** already follows the rating band of Handicap mode, and now varies within it too. With width 1 nothing changes: the best move is played, as before.

New and changed options

Option	Type, default	What changes in 9.1
LiveBook Width	Integer 1–20, default 1	New: random choice among the best move and the equivalent ones (see above)
LiveBook Timeout	Integer 100–60000 ms, default 5000	A request also never takes more than half of the optimum time of the move
ChessDB Tablebase, Lichess Tablebase	Check, default false	Used whenever the Syzygy tablebases cannot probe the position, also with a SyzygyPath set
LiveBook Depth	Integer 1–255 plies, default 255	Unchanged; with at most 7 pieces the opening live books are no longer queried

Bug fixes

- **Crash on ChessDB**: an answer with an unknown score (`score:??`), possible in tablebase positions, stopped the engine.
- **ChessDB tablebase moves**: the `egtb:` moves sent by a proxy (query and querybest) were ignored; now they are played.
- **go depth and go nodes**: the live books answered and the engine played without searching. Now they follow the rules of the CTG/BIN books; when pondering they still work, and on a ponderhit the book move comes at once.
- **Endgames up to 7 pieces**: with a SyzygyPath set, the opening live books were queried and the online tablebases skipped, even with missing or smaller tablebase files. Now the online tablebases are used whenever the Syzygy tablebases cannot probe the position.
- **Time**: a slow or hanging server could cost the game on time. A request now takes at most half of the optimum time of the move, and the HTTP connection is reused between requests.
- **go searchmoves**: a CTG/BIN or experience book move outside searchmoves made the engine play an unsearched move. Now it searches.
- **Large Lichess counts**: the totals of the explorer are summed in 64 bits.

- **Build**: incremental builds could mix objects compiled with different versions of the live book classes.

Upgrade notes

1. With the default options Alexander 9.1 plays like 9: LiveBook Width is 1 and the search is unchanged.
2. The Lichess live books still need **LiveBook Lichess Token**, created at lichess.org/account/oauth/token without any scope.
3. The live books are no longer used with `go depth` and `go nodes`. With at most 7 pieces they give way to the local Syzygy tablebases when these can probe the position.
4. With very little time (an optimum under about 200 ms per move) the live books are skipped, so that a request cannot cost the game on time.